

Natchez Trace Parkway

Lower Trace Self-Guided Cycling Tour

Natchez, MS → Rocky Springs, MS

PACE	LODGING	SEASON	TRANSPORT
Moderate (3 days)	B&B; / Inn	Spring	Driving

DISTANCE	DIFFICULTY	BEST SEASONS	BIKES
~82 Miles	Beginner	Spring / Fall	ROAD, HYBRID, EBIKE

ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

START POINT	Natchez Visitor Center, Natchez, MS (Milepost 0)
END POINT	Rocky Springs Campsite, MS (Milepost 54.8)
RESUPPLY	Natchez (start), Port Gibson (MP 39.2) — stock up, limited options between
CASH	Bring cash — many small towns and local restaurants are cash only
CELL SERVICE	Spotty in many sections — download offline maps before departing
TRAFFIC	No trucks or commercial vehicles ever permitted on the Parkway
WATER	Available at NPS visitor centers and campgrounds — carry 2L minimum
EMERGENCY	NPS Ranger Station: (601) 446-6672 · Call 911 for emergencies

SPRING RIDING CONDITIONS

March–May is peak season. Wildflowers are spectacular. Book B&Bs; 6+ weeks ahead. Insects emerge in April — pack repellent. Mornings can be cool (40s°F), afternoons warm (70s°F). Best overall window: mid-March to early May.

GETTING THERE & BACK

Leave your car at the Natchez Visitor Center (free, secure NPS lot). Arrange a return shuttle to pick you up at Rocky Springs on your final day, or have someone drive your car to meet you.

DAY 1 · 1 of 3

ARRIVAL & NATCHEZ EXPLORATION

No riding today — arrival day.

Arrive in Natchez — one of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River. Spend the afternoon and evening exploring before your ride begins tomorrow.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Natchez sits on a bluff 200 feet above the Mississippi River and has been continuously inhabited for over 10,000 years. The Natchez people maintained their capital here until colonial wars in the 1730s dispersed them. By the early 1800s, Natchez had become the wealthiest city per capita in the United States — built on cotton and enslaved labor. The antebellum mansions you see today are the legacy of that era. The city was largely spared during the Civil War, preserving much of its extraordinary 19th century architecture intact.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Natchez Bluffs & Under-the-Hill The bluffs overlook the Mississippi — best at sunset. Under-the-Hill was once the most notorious district on the frontier.	Walk
● Stanton Hall One of the grandest antebellum mansions in America. Tours run daily. Allow 60-90 min. Book ahead in spring.	Tour
● Longwood An unfinished octagonal mansion — construction stopped when the Civil War began and was never resumed. Upper floors still hold the builder's tools. 4.9★	Tour
● Historic Natchez City Cemetery Extraordinary 19th century monuments. Free, open daily. Allow 30 minutes.	Walk

OVERNIGHT: NATCHEZ, MS

One of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River. Rich antebellum history, excellent dining, and the most B&B; options on the route.

The Burn Luxury Inn ★	\$150–200/night
Stunning antebellum property, full breakfast included, pool and gardens. Nell is an exceptional host.	Booking.com or direct
Sunnyside B&B; ★	\$125–175/night
Intimate, owner Colleen is fascinating — expect a 3-hour breakfast conversation about the home's history.	Direct: (601) 807-1148
Riverboat B&B;	\$125–150/night
Bikes welcome, great central location, homemade breakfast with farm-fresh eggs.	Direct: (601) 445-8217

DINING TONIGHT

Natchez has the best dining on the route. Magnolia Grill for a river-view first night, or Frankie's on Main for something special.

Magnolia Grill	Seafood / Southern	\$	<i>Tue–Sun 11am–9/10pm, closed Mon</i>
Shrimp & grits, river view, right Under-the-Hill. The obvious first-night pick. 4.5★ / 1,700 reviews.			(601) 446-7670
Frankie's on Main	American / Upscale	\$	<i>Tue–Sat 11am–10pm, closed Sun–Mon</i>
Renovated bank building, excellent food, great atmosphere. Best for a celebratory first night. 4.6★			(601) 861-6713
The Camp	Casual / American	\$	<i>Daily 11am–8/9pm</i>
Also Under-the-Hill, river views, more casual. Catfish, burgers, great atmosphere. 4.5★			(601) 897-0466

BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Natchez Coffee Co	Mon–Sat 6am–5pm, Sun 6am–2pm	\$
Opens 6am. Very popular with locals. Perfect pre-ride fuel. 4.3★ / 800+ reviews.		(601) 304-1415
The Little Easy	Daily 8am–2pm (Fri also 6–9pm)	\$
Chicken & waffles, mimosas, charming atmosphere. Great if you have a relaxed morning. 4.3★		(601) 653-0774

DAY 2 · 2 of 3

NATCHEZ TO PORT GIBSON

~42 miles · Rolling hills · Smooth NPS asphalt all day

Your first day of riding begins at the Natchez Visitor Center. The Parkway wraps you in forest and calm immediately. Keep eyes open for deer, wild turkey, and armadillos in the early miles. Smooth NPS pavement, light car traffic, and your pace entirely your own.

TERRAIN & SURFACE

A longer day but consistent terrain — smooth NPS asphalt with a 3-5ft paved shoulder throughout. Gentle rolling hills through dense hardwood forest. No significant climbs. The biggest elevation is gradual and spread over miles. Moderate pace riders typically complete this in 3.5-5 hours of riding time.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

This is the most historically dense day on the route. Emerald Mound at mile 10 is one of the most significant pre-Columbian sites in the country — a ceremonial platform mound covering eight acres, built by the Plaquemine culture between 1300-1600 CE. Further north, Mount Locust was the first inn on the Trace, serving the boatmen walking home to Nashville after floating goods to New Orleans. The Sunken Trace near mile 25 shows the physical depth of the route's history — the trail worn six to eight feet below grade by centuries of foot and hoof traffic.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Emerald Mound (MP 10.3)

Must Stop — Allow 30 min

Second largest Native American earthwork in the US. Climb to the top. The size is staggering — eight acres at the base, built basket by basket.

● Mount Locust Inn (MP 15.5)

Stop — Allow 15 min

Built 1779, the oldest remaining inn on the Old Trace. NPS interpretive talks in spring. The surrounding grounds are beautiful.

● Sunken Trace (MP 25.0)

Stop — Allow 15 min

The original trail worn six to eight feet below grade by centuries of use. Walking down into it changes your relationship to the history.

● Port Gibson Church Street

Evening Walk

The Golden Hand steeple of First Presbyterian Church is unmistakable — and unexplained. Walk Church Street before dinner.

LUNCH OPTIONS

Coles Creek Picnic Area (MP 35)	NPS Picnic Area	Free
Ideal lunch stop — shaded tables, restrooms, water. Bring food from Natchez or your B&B; breakfast.		
Natchez Coffee Co (pre-ride)	Cafe	\$
Stock up before you leave. Limited options until Port Gibson.		

CUE SHEET

MILE	LANDMARK	DIRECTION	NOTES
0.0	Natchez Visitor Center — START	Head N	Parking, restrooms, water. Official Parkway start.
1.2	Under-the-Hill area	Continue N	Optional last coffee/food stop before the Trace.
10.3	Emerald Mound	Turn R	MUST STOP. 2nd largest Native American mound in US. Sunrise here is magical. Allow 30 min.
15.5	Mount Locust Historic Inn	Continue N	Oldest remaining inn on the Old Natchez Trace. NPS interpretive site.
17.5	Loess Bluff	Continue N	Unique geological formation. Short walk to overlook.
25.0	Sunken Trace	Continue N	Walk the original sunken trail worn by centuries of foot traffic.
30.0	Grindstone Ford / Mangum Mound	Continue N	Ancient mound and creek crossing. Good shaded rest stop.
35.0	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	Good lunch stop. Restrooms and water available.
39.2	PORT GIBSON — END DAY 2	Exit L	Turn left toward town. Motels and B&Bs.; RESUPPLY HERE for Day 3.

OVERNIGHT: PORT GIBSON, MS

Called "too beautiful to burn" by General Grant during the Civil War. Small historic town with excellent B&B; options. Dining is limited — plan accordingly.

Isabella Bed & Breakfast ★	\$100–150/night
Cyclist-specific reviews praise this place — locked bike storage, cold drinks waiting on arrival, expert local tips. 4.9★	Direct: (601) 437-5097
Collina House	\$100–150/night
Gorgeous 1800s plantation property, very welcoming hosts Scott and Katy, full breakfast. 5.0★	Direct: (504) 481-3166

DINING TONIGHT

Port Gibson: limited options but the Isabella or Collina hosts always know what's good and open. The 61 Fish Market closes at 7pm — worth it for the catfish.

Ask your B&B; host	Local recommendation	varies	—
-------------------------------	----------------------	---------------	---

Port Gibson dining options change frequently. Both Isabella and Collina hosts are excellent at current restaurant recommendations. The town is small — trust local knowledge.			—
61 Fish Market	Seafood	\$	Daily 9am–7pm (Sun noon–6pm)
Fresh fried catfish, open until 7pm. Good early dinner option if you arrive before 6:30pm. 4.5★			(601) 437-4009

BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Your B&B; hosts	By arrangement	Included
Both Isabella and Collina serve full Southern breakfasts. This is genuinely the best meal option in town — take your time and fuel up for the day.		—
Mississippi's Finest	Mon–Sat 11am–3pm, closed Sun	\$
Opens at 11am — good lunch stop rather than breakfast. Fried chicken and rice & gravy are exceptional. 4.7★		(601) 448-5277

★ **PORT GIBSON OVERNIGHT:** First Presbyterian Church (the Golden Hand steeple) is a must-see on your evening walk. The Corner on Church B&B; is highly recommended. Dinner: ask your host for current restaurant recommendations.

DAY 3 · 3 of 3

PORT GIBSON TO ROCKY SPRINGS

~40 miles · Rolling hills · NPS asphalt + Windsor Ruins detour on county road

Today features the single most memorable detour on the Lower Trace — the Windsor Ruins. Plan extra time. The day ends at Rocky Springs, a ghost town slowly reclaimed by forest, where the free NPS campsite sits among ruins of what was once a community of 2,600 people.

TERRAIN & SURFACE

Your longest day. Smooth NPS asphalt throughout, with one notable exception: the Windsor Ruins detour onto Rodney Road is a narrow 2-lane county road with no shoulder. Ride single file, stay right. The detour is 1.5 miles each way on rougher pavement. The final approach to Rocky Springs includes a 0.3-mile gravel access road to the campsite — walk it if you're on 25mm road tires.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Windsor Ruins and Rocky Springs tell two very different stories about the antebellum South's rise and fall. Windsor was the grandest mansion in Mississippi, built in 1861 and surviving the Civil War only to burn in 1890 from a dropped cigarette — 23 cast-iron columns are all that remain. Rocky Springs, by contrast, was a community of ordinary people whose town was slowly erased by yellow fever, war, soil exhaustion, and the boll weevil. The 1837 Methodist Church still stands among the ruins, holding services until 1904. Both sites sit quietly in the forest now, reclaimed by the same landscape that once fed them.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Windsor Ruins (MP 30 detour)

Must Stop — Allow 45-60 min

Turn onto Rodney Road at MP 30. 1.5 miles to the ruins. Twenty-three Corinthian columns in a forest clearing. Open sky, no walls, vines climbing the ironwork. It earns the detour.

● Sunken Trace, Section 2 (MP 45.7)

Stop — Allow 15 min

The deeper of the two Sunken Trace sections. If you missed the first one, don't miss this.

● Owens Creek Waterfall (MP 50.0)

Quick Stop

Small waterfall, 2-min trail. Cool and shaded — a good final rest before camp.

● Rocky Springs Ghost Town (MP 54.8)

Explore at camp

Walk the ghost town trail at dusk. The 1837 church, foundations, and the original spring are all within easy walking distance of the campsite.

LUNCH OPTIONS

Pack from Port Gibson	Essential	\$
Last food before Rocky Springs. The 61 Fish Market at MP 39 is your best bet — get there before 12:30pm for lunch, or pack from your B&B; breakfast.		
Coles Creek Picnic Area (MP 47.5)	Last Water Stop	Free
FILL ALL BOTTLES HERE. This is the last reliable water before Rocky Springs. Do not skip this stop.		

CUE SHEET

MILE	LANDMARK	DIRECTION	NOTES
0.0	Port Gibson — START DAY 3	To Pkwy	Stock up food and water. Limited resupply ahead.
1.0	Re-enter Natchez Trace Pkwy	Head N	Resume from MP 39.2. Continue northbound.
41.0	Windsor Ruins Turnoff	Turn LEFT	MUST STOP. Onto Rodney Rd — 0.5 mi to ruins. 23 haunting columns in the forest. Allow 45-60 min.
41.5	Return to Parkway	Turn RIGHT	Rejoin Parkway heading north after Windsor Ruins.
45.7	Sunken Trace (2nd section)	Continue N	Original deeply worn trail. Short walk, very worth it.
47.5	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	LAST WATER before Rocky Springs. Fill all bottles here.
50.0	Owens Creek Waterfall	Continue N	Small but lovely waterfall. Easy 2-min walk off road.
54.8	Rocky Springs — END	Turn R	Free NPS camping. Water at site. Ghost town ruins and 1837 church nearby.

■ IMPORTANT WARNINGS

- No food or dining options at Rocky Springs — carry dinner and breakfast from Port Gibson.
- No cell service — download offline maps and tell someone your plan before leaving Port Gibson.
- No power available — e-bike riders should charge fully in Port Gibson.

OVERNIGHT: ROCKY SPRINGS, MS

A ghost town at the end of the line. No services, no cell service, no restaurants — just the NPS campsite, ruins, and extraordinary stargazing.

Rocky Springs NPS Campground ★	Free
First come, first served. Water spigot on site. Bear boxes provided. The 1837 Methodist Church and ghost town ruins are a short walk away.	No reservation needed

DINING TONIGHT

- No food at Rocky Springs. Carry dinner and tomorrow's breakfast from Port Gibson. Non-negotiable.

★ *ROCKY SPRINGS CAMP: Water spigot on site. Bear boxes provided. Walk the ghost town trail at dusk — ruins of stores, homes and the standing church are extraordinary. No cell service. Stargazing exceptional on clear nights.*

GEAR LIST · NAVIGATION · SHUTTLE

WHAT TO PACK

ALL RIDERS

Navigation	Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps or Gaia GPS), this cue sheet	<i>Garmin or Wahoo GPS with GPX loaded</i>
Clothing	Padded shorts, jersey x2, lightweight rain jacket, arm warmers	<i>Chamois cream, sun sleeves for hot days</i>
Safety	Front and rear lights, helmet, ID, emergency contacts, basic first aid	<i>Personal locator beacon for remote sections</i>
Other	Cash \$50+ minimum, sunscreen, insect repellent (essential spring)	<i>Small padlock for bike at overnight stops</i>

INN-TO-INN

Bike	Road or hybrid bike, spare tubes x2, pump, multi-tool, chain lube	<i>Handlebar bag or small frame bag</i>
Luggage	Small backpack or handlebar bag — B&Bs; carry your overnight essentials	<i>Lightweight dry bag for rain protection</i>
Food & Water	2x bottles minimum, snacks for the day — meals at restaurants nightly	<i>Electrolyte tabs for hot days</i>

NAVIGATION & MAPS

GPX File	Import to Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, Ride with GPS, or Apple Maps	<i>Included in your download from openride.bike</i>
Ride with GPS	View interactive map, turn cues on your phone, export GPX	<i>ridewithgps.com — search OpenRide Natchez Trace</i>
Google Maps Offline	Download the region over WiFi before your trip	<i>Open Google Maps → find area → tap Download</i>
NPS Parkway Map	Official map with all mileposts, facilities, campgrounds marked	<i>nps.gov/natr — free PDF download</i>
Komoot	Excellent cycling-specific routing and navigation app	<i>komoot.com — search Natchez Trace</i>

SHUTTLE & LOGISTICS

Leave your car at the Natchez Visitor Center (free, secure NPS lot). Arrange a return shuttle to pick you up at Rocky Springs on your final day, or have someone drive your car to meet you.

BikeFlights.com ships your bike to your hotel and back home. Starts around \$60 each way. Book 1–2 weeks ahead.

This route guide was curated by a professional bicycle tour guide with over 10 years of experience leading tours on the Natchez Trace Parkway. Every stop, every note, and every recommendation comes from real miles ridden on this road.

openride.bike